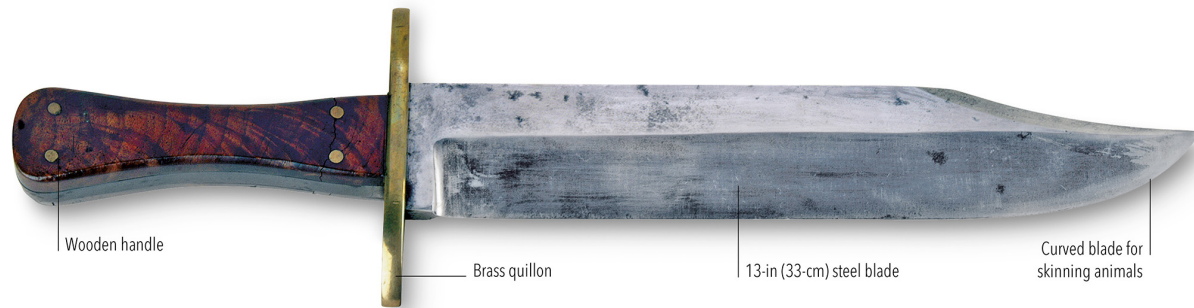




Confederate Bowie knife

Probably designed by Rezin Bowie (brother of Jim Bowie) for cowboys to catch and skin animals, the Bowie knife was a standard Confederate weapon. This one was found on the battlefield at Perryville.

In the Stones River Valley

Bragg faced criticism for his decision but he kept his job. Buell did not, and was replaced by Major General William S. Rosecrans as head of what would soon become known as the Army of the Cumberland. Bragg and Smith ended up at Murfreesboro, Tennessee, in the Stones River Valley, with their armies united to form the Army of Tennessee under Bragg's command.

On December 26, Rosecrans marched out of Nashville to engage Bragg, in response to Lincoln's continued pressure for offensive action. By December 30, he was facing the Confederates at Stones River. That evening, bands from both armies struck up to help raise their men's spirits. In the words of Sam Seay of the Confederates' 1st Tennessee Infantry, "The still winter night carried [the bands'] strains to great distance. At every pause on our side, far away could be heard the military bands of the other. Finally one of them struck up 'Home Sweet Home.' As if by common consent, all other airs ceased, and the bands of both armies as far as the ear could reach, joined in the refrain."

The next morning, real battle succeeded the previous night's dueling bands. The Confederates attacked at dawn, catching the Union troops still eating their breakfast. The panicked Union right wing was driven back 3 miles (4.8km) in what would have been a fatal rout, but for resistance organized by Sheridan, who held a position for four hours at great cost to his division. A Union